



Frequently Asked Questions

Why are you making this change?

Updates to Keeping Children Safe in Education 2023 (the statutory government safeguarding legislation for schools) highlighted the requirement of schools to include filtering and monitoring within their safeguarding policy and procedures. Up to this point, in response to the legislation, staff have been physically monitoring student activity on devices in their classrooms. With the rapid development of technology, and the ubiquity of laptop use in the school, this system is no longer fit for purpose. We have to make a long term plan to ensure we are adequately safeguarding our students online, and fulfilling our statutory duties, without compromising our educational offering.

Whilst we are making changes to our laptop policy, we have incorporated the requirements of Ed Tech for the curriculum, and therefore introducing the active stylus capability at the same time.

What does monitoring mean?

Smoothwall Monitor runs in the background analysing keystrokes. It is looking for certain safeguarding keywords by looking at what is typed, so it can spot serious risks such as self-harm, bullying or violence. It only reacts if those specific words or patterns appear and ignores normal day-to-day work. It does not spy on students, does not watch everything they do, does not record all keystrokes, and cannot access cameras or microphones.

Why does this not also apply to year 10 and 11?

We have made the decision to stagger the roll out of the policy, to support parents who have already purchased devices, and joined the school, under the BYOD policy. Physical monitoring of these devices will continue. All new joiners will be subject to the new policy. We will be fully compliant, with all devices managed by the school by 2028.

Why are you not using an external company to manage this?

To save parents money. We have investigated options, through a management company. Laptops were significantly more expensive (up to 50% more) compared to allowing parents to buy the device directly, and the school controlled the management themselves.

What does the technology bundle include?

- Microsoft 365 A3 licence for students, which includes full access to Microsoft apps (desktop, web and mobile), OneDrive cloud storage, Teams, and enhanced security features.
- Microsoft Intune for Education for device management, allowing the school to keep student devices secure, updated, and app deployment.
- Windows 11 Pro
- Smoothwall Filter and Monitor
- SentinelOne anti-virus and security

Can we have administrative control over the summer holidays?

This will not be possible. A member of the IT team is always working during the holidays (excluding public holidays, and Christmas closure) and will be able to deal with reasonable support requests



Frequently Asked Questions

Can filtering and monitoring be turned off during weekends and holidays?

No, this will not be possible. Filtering and monitoring stay active at all times while the device is managed. This protects students and ensures safeguarding requirements are met, even when the laptop is used at home.

Can I book an appointment for the set up?

We won't be offering appointment slots. Instead students can hand their laptops to the IT team during the set up window we publish. Devices will be processed in the order they arrive, and we will let students know as soon as they are ready for collection.

Please ensure that the device or its bag is clearly labelled with the student's name and class. If the laptop has a password, make sure the password is written clearly on the label. If the password is missing or incorrect, it will delay the setup process.

What happens if the laptop gets broken or stolen?

The laptop remains the responsibility of students and parents. The school manages the software, but any hardware care, damage, or loss falls under parent responsibility. If a device is damaged or stolen, the school will investigate the incident where appropriate to understand what happened and support next steps.

If parents wish to have additional protection, they may choose to purchase their own insurance cover for accidental damage, loss, or theft.

What happens if I don't buy a laptop?

The student will not be able to bring in their own laptop, they may be able to use a limited number of school devices outside of exam periods. Only laptops managed by the school will be allowed to be used in year 9 in 2026.

Can I buy an Apple device?

No. We require all students to use a Windows laptop. To manage devices properly for teaching, learning and safeguarding, we need everyone on the same operating system. Using only Windows laptops ensures that:

- all students have access to the same software and learning tools
- our IT team can support, update and secure all devices consistently
- teachers can give the same instructions to the whole class
- lessons run smoothly with fewer technical issues

This consistency helps create a reliable and effective digital learning environment for all students.

My son/daughter will be using the laptop for months after Christmas. What will happen to any software or information on the laptop when it is set up?

The School policy will be that the device will need to be reset to factory settings. This removes all existing files and installed software, so please ensure anything important is backed up before the appointment.



Frequently Asked Questions

What happens when we leave the school?

When a student leaves, the laptop will be factory reset and ownership returned to the family. Students will receive advance notice to back up any personal files to a personal cloud storage or a USB drive before the reset takes place.

I have a son/daughter in Year 10/11 who already has a device? Is this applicable to them?

No. This programme is being rolled out year by year, starting with Year 9. So for the academic year 2026/27, only Year 9 students will be required to follow this policy. In the following year (2027/28) Year 9 and 10 will follow this policy and so on. However, if parents wish to join their son/daughter to have a higher degree of protection, we are happy to include their laptop in this year's scheme.

Can administrative control be taken without wiping the laptop?

The School policy will be that the device will need to be reset to factory settings. This removes all existing files and installed software, so please ensure anything important is backed up before the appointment. The laptop must be reset to ensure it starts clean and is fully secured.

What happens to any software that is originally on the laptop?

Once a factory reset has been completed, this reinstalls the operating system and any pre-installed software that came with the laptop.

Can parents create another user account (for example, for a sibling)?

No. While the device is managed by the school, only school-issued accounts can be used. This ensures safeguarding and consistent security settings.

If a sibling also attends the school and has their own school account, they may use the device by logging in with that account.

Personal or non-school accounts cannot be added while the device is under school management. Once the student leaves and the device is removed from management, families may add any accounts they wish.

What is the deadline to hand in laptops for onboarding?

Friday 3rd July 2026.

Can students personalise the laptop?

External stickers are not allowed as laptops need to be easily identified as school managed. However internal stickers may be used. Internal settings such as wallpapers or system customisation may be restricted under device management.

Will the IT team downgrade Windows from Pro to Home when a student leaves?

No. When a student leaves, the device will be removed from school management and factory reset, but the IT team will not downgrade the operating system.



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How long does the laptop battery need to last for a school day?

Laptops should have a minimum all-day battery life of at least 6–8 hours, as students may not always be able to charge during lessons.

Can students charge in school?

Students should bring devices fully charged each day. Charging points in classrooms are limited and are only used in emergencies. Students need permission from the teacher before using any charging points in the classroom.

If my child loses the stylus, is that my responsibility?

Stylus pens are part of the student's equipment list. If lost or damaged, replacements must be purchased by parents.

Will it stop me from loading my own software?

Yes, in most cases. Because the laptop will be managed by the school for safeguarding and security, only approved software can be installed. Students and parents will not have administrator rights during enrolment, so personal software, games, or applications that are not required for learning cannot be added.

If there is a specific piece of software needed for schoolwork, you may request approval from the IT team, and they will review whether it can be safely installed.

Will the school pay the Microsoft 365 licence? If not, can I use my own 365 family licence account?

Yes. The cost of the Microsoft 365 A3 licence will be covered through the annual technology bundle fee, which is added to the school bill. This ensures every student has the same secure, school-managed setup.

Will there be any impact on home network configurations or device compatibility?

No. School management will **not** change your home Wi-Fi settings, router configuration, or internet setup. The device will connect to your home network in the same way as any normal Windows laptop.

The installed safeguarding software only works on the device itself, they do not affect your home network or other household devices. There should be no impact on how your home devices function.

Will it be able to have access to personal information either loaded locally or accessible on the home network?

No. The school's monitoring and security tools cannot see or scan any other devices on your home network.

The monitoring system checks for specific safeguarding keywords typed on the student's school-managed device (e.g. terms linked to self-harm, bullying, violence, or exploitation).



Frequently Asked Questions

How does Claremont compare to other local private schools? Are we ahead of/behind the curve in implementation?

Other schools use a variety of options:

- A stock of school managed devices that are booked out for certain classes. In this scenario, laptops are not the default way of working, and not used in the majority of classes. No personal devices are allowed.
- The school issues each student with a school managed device. The cost of this is either explicitly on the school bill, or built into the fees. No personal devices are allowed.
- Parents lease/buy a device from an external company that supports the school with the management of the device. The cost is either explicitly on the school bill, paid directly by parents, or built into the fees. No personal devices are allowed.
- Only devices that have safeguarding controls downloaded, and controlled by the school are allowed.

Future proofing our students to give them experience of fully Integrating IT within all aspects of learning, including assessments, is essential. As a school we are already doing this for all subjects but there is a barrier in regards to equity in functionality of IT equipment. With this proposal we will ensure that all students are given equal opportunity to learn new skills and be as prepared for both exams and the future world of work.

Will it still be active if the device is taken abroad?

Yes. The safeguarding and security tools on the laptop work on the device itself, not through the school network. This means monitoring and security protections will remain active even if the laptop is used abroad, as long as it is connected to the internet.

All school services (Teams, OneDrive, email, apps) will also continue to work normally when the device has an active internet connection.

Is any personal user data held?

Smoothwall Monitor and Smoothwall Filter will not collect and store any information other than for the specific use at the time of filtering and use. The school can not access this information from Smoothwall Monitor unless flagged by the system by use of a screenshot. Any other personal files stored on the laptop will be backed up to school systems. The Device should only be used for school related work and data

Who can see safeguarding information/alerts?

Safeguarding alerts are only seen by the school's Designated Safeguarding Leaders and authorised members of the safeguarding team. The IT team does not review content unless specifically asked to support a safeguarding concern. The alerts are handled confidentially and follow strict procedures.



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What about phone usage in school? Will the phone policy be changed/tightened?

Students are not allowed phones in years 9-11. If they are required for specific purposes e.g. journey to and from school, they must be handed into the school office. Our policy on phones remains unchanged.

Can students hotspot their phones to avoid filtering?

If a student is using a school-managed laptop, the safeguarding system remains active, even when connected to a mobile hotspot instead of the school network.

If a student uses a personal device (BYOD) on their own hotspot, the school cannot apply filtering or monitoring. Using a personal device in this way to bypass the system is not permitted and will be treated as a safeguarding and behaviour concern.

At the senior school mobile data is very limited, and hotspotting is not possible.